

Review Essay

Magic in Islam between Religion and Science

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SEBASTIAN GÜNTHER and DOROTHEE PIELOW, EDS. *Die Geheimnisse der oberen und der unteren Welt: Magie im Islam zwischen Glaube und Wissenschaft*. (Islamic History and Civilization: Studies and Texts.) Leiden: Brill, 2019. Pp. xlii + 644.

Secrets of the Higher World and the Lower (hereafter *Secrets*) stands dense testament to several new turns in the study of Islamicate societies, both past and present, from arabophone to anglophone and every tongue between. No longer can they be confined to the Cold War holding cell that is the “Middle East”; no longer can the philologist and the anthropologist remain innocent of the other’s findings; no longer can Muslims’ perennial preoccupation with magic and its associated occult sciences and technologies be reduced to superstition and touted as proof of Islamic anti-modern decadence.¹ Based on the

* My thanks to Claire Fanger, Nicholas Harris, Maria Subtelny, Dylan Burns, Nühket Varlık, and Christian Mauder for their helpful comments on a draft of this essay.

1. Epitomizing this reductionist declinism is Armand Abel, “La place des sciences occultes dans la décadence,” in *Classicism et déclin culturel dans l’histoire de l’Islam*, R. Brunschvig and G. E. von Grunebaum (Paris: Editions Besson Chantemerle, 1957), 291–311. For a survey and critique of such positivist scholarship, see Richard Lemay, “L’Islam historiques et les sciences occultes,” *Bulletin d’Études Orientales* 44 (1992): 19–37; Matthew Melvin-Koushki, “Powers of One: The Mathematicalization of the Occult Sciences in the High Persianate Tradition,” *Intellectual History of the Islamic World* 5 (2017): 127–99. For a brief definition of the Islamicate “occult sciences” (*al-‘ulūm al-khafiyya* or *al-gharība*), including astrology, alchemy, and various forms of magic and divination, see Noah Gardiner, s.v., in *Encyclopedia of Islam and the Muslim World*, ed. Richard C. Martin, 2 vols., 2nd ed. (San Francisco: Gale Cengage Learning, 2016), 2:815–17.

conference *Magie im Islam* convened at the University of Göttingen by Ingrid Hehmeyer and Sebastian Günther in 2012, the hefty volume here under review (almost seven hundred pages!) reflects, and refracts, the sudden spate of dissertations, books, edited collections, articles, conferences, and conference panels on this long-scorned theme in the last decade. It would appear that the academic study of Islamic Magic is finally becoming respectable.

But that study remains a tiny new field—one hacked, as it were, out of a vast textual and material-cultural jungle through which few hunting trails or trade arteries run. Several hundreds of thousands of relevant surviving texts and artifacts (a small fraction of what was originally produced) sit moldering in archives and private collections, many uncatalogued and most entirely untouched; in any other philological field this would be hailed a bonanza. Even the most seminal Arabic grimoires of the “classical” era remain woefully understudied—unless, of course, they happened to have been done into Latin—² and their far more abundant early modern and modern counterparts in other Islamicate languages, especially Persian, studied virtually not at all. We Islamicists still await our Thorndike, to say nothing of our Yates.

The volume in question is thus equally a testament to the inchoateness and obscurity of this nascent field. It is necessarily both tentative and motley, and cannot yet offer a view to the horizon. We cannot see the forest for the trees.

As such, *Secrets* is best read in tandem with three other conference-based volumes on the same theme, two published in the last two years, and one forthcoming next year, which together hint at what might be possible in the study of Islamic Magic going forward:

- 1) *Islamicate Occultism: New Perspectives*, based on a conference organized by myself at Princeton University in February 2014 and co-edited with Noah Gardiner as a special double issue of *Arabica* (64, nos. 3–4 [2017]: 287–693). This volume was the first to emphasize developments—especially imperial—in the early modern Persianate world, while combining philological and art-historical/material-cultural approaches. Its ten chapters deal with such sciences as lettrism, geomancy, astrology, alchemy, and physiognomy, and such technologies as talismanic shirts. Taken together, they outline a radically revisionist account of the evolution of Islamicate occultism over the last millennium—this to prompt

2. E.g., the tenth-century *Goal of the Sage* (*Ghāyat al-ḥakīm*), aka the *Picatrix*; but here too the scholarly focus to date has been on the Latin translation/adaptation rather than on the Arabic original.

a new generation of Islamicists to finally move beyond tired, colonialist tropes of Islamic Magic as bad religion and bad science both.

- 2) *The Occult Sciences in Pre-modern Islamic Cultures* (Beirut: Orient-Institut Beirut, 2018), based on a conference held in December 2013 at the American University of Beirut and coedited by Nader El-Bizri and Eva Orthmann (also a contributor to *Secrets*). Its ten chapters treat of such sciences as arithmology, medicine, physiognomy, astronomy, meteorology, geomancy, lettrism, alchemy, astrology, and cryptology, with a balanced medieval and early modern Arabic and Persian focus; it takes an exclusively philological approach.
- 3) *Islamicate Occult Sciences in Theory and Practice* (Leiden: Brill, forthcoming 2020), based on a conference held in January 2017 at the Ashmolean Museum in Oxford and coedited by the organizers Liana Saif, Francesca Leoni, myself, and Farouk Yahya, expands on these models to further escape the arabo-, classico- and Middle East-centrism still plaguing the field, all spawned by endemic Eurocentrism; and it too puts philologists and art and material culture historians into conversation, thus combining theory and practice to an unprecedented degree. Its twelve chapters range widely temporally and geographically, spanning from the ninth century to the present and the Islamicate heartlands to Southeast Asia, and covering such sciences and technologies as magic, magic squares, lettrism, astrology, talismans, and amulets.

Prior to these volumes, the state of the field around the turn of the millennium was represented by Emilie Savage-Smith's edited collection *Magic and Divination in Early Islam* (Aldershot: Ashgate, 2004). Unlike them, however, this collection was not based on a conference, but brings together ten articles in English published between 1938 and 2003, and (as per the title) covers late antiquity to the thirteenth century. It focuses almost exclusively on Arabic materials dealing variously with medicine, magic, talismans, seals, meteorology, geomancy, and astrology.³ As Savage-Smith notes (xv), her selection of articles was designed to expand the scope of two pioneering special journal issues of the previous decade: "Sciences occultes et Islam," edited by Pierre Lory and Annick (Anne) Regourd (*Bulletin d'Études Orientales* 44 [1992]: 9–241), comprising fourteen articles in French and English; and "Divination,

3. The groundbreaking collection *The Occult Sciences in Byzantium*, edited by Paul Magdalino and Maria Mavroudi (Geneva: La Pomme d'Or, 2006), and comprising eleven articles spanning from late antiquity to the fifteenth century, must also be mentioned here.

magie, pouvoirs au Yémen,” edited by Anne Regourd (*Quaderni di Studi Arabi* 13 [1995]: 3–226), comprising twelve articles in French, English, Italian, and German. In their combining of rigorous philology with art history and material culture studies on the one hand and anthropology on the other, these two volumes together set the interdisciplinary standard that Islamicists must more widely emulate henceforth.

Secrets is the only volume since to combine all four disciplines, adding comparative literature to the mix; and its temporal, geographical, and thematic scope is unprecedented in the field to date. It spans from the seventh century to the twenty-first, and from West Africa, Iberia, and Egypt to Yemen, Iraq, Armenia, Iran, and India, albeit with an overriding focus on materials in Arabic. (The editors flag the study of materials in other Islamicate languages as a major desideratum). Its sixteen chapters and very long (over one-hundred-page) introduction investigate a range of theological and legal debates over and polemics against “magic,” as well as its lived social realities and literary deployments from premodernity to the present, and covers such sciences and technologies as medicine, lettrism, astrology, geomancy, magic squares, magic bowls, talismans, amulets, and amulet scrolls. Equally crucially, its fairly exhaustive bibliographies together offer an invaluable snapshot of the state of the field as of 2017, i.e., just before the first two volumes above appeared, and exceptionally incorporate secondary scholarship in Arabic produced over the last decades. This volume, in short, is the first of its kind in any European language, and will function as an essential reference work for specialists going forward.

Nevertheless, *Secrets* remains largely tied to the core thematic areas established by Manfred Ullmann, Emilie Savage-Smith, and Toufic Fahd, as the editors acknowledge, and hence explicitly arabocentric.⁴ Given that few of its contributors have a background in the history of Islamicate occultism, however, such dependency is surely prudent. More problematically, the volume as a whole presents its Islamicate case studies as hermetically (*sic*) sealed off from the infinitely more extensive study of western European (Christian and Jewish) cognates. Of the burgeoning field of *Western esotericism studies*—the most obvious point of contact and comparison—there is not a word.⁵

4. The three model volumes here are Ullmann’s *Die Natur- und Geheimwissenschaften im Islam* (Leiden: Brill, 1972); Savage-Smith’s abovementioned *Magic and Divination in Early Islam*; and Fahd’s *La divination arabe: études religieuses, sociologiques et folkloriques sur le milieu natif de l’Islam* (Leiden: Brill, 1966).

5. As a case in point, Wouter Hanegraaff’s indispensable and programmatic *Esotericism in the Academy: Rejected Knowledge in Western Culture* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2012) is glaringly absent from all of the many bibliographies in the

Islamic Magic thus still appears here as Western modernity's most occulted Other—rather than as an integral and indispensable part of the story of the (Rise of the) West.⁶ The exception is Otto's crucial theoretical essay, written from a Europeanist perspective, which goes some way toward repairing this structural problem, as I will discuss below.

As an aid to specialists and non-specialists who would reincorporate both Islam and Magic into that story generally and Western esotericism studies specifically, I will be fairly thorough in my summary of *Secrets*, and identify those of its arguments that must be pursued and those of its mistakes that must be avoided going forward.



The editors' introduction (Chapter 1), as noted, is remarkable in its sweep and comprehensiveness, apart from its lack of attention to the vigorous debates in Western esotericism scholarship. But it does not venture to diagnose the colonialist causes for the almost total exclusion of "magic" from Islamic studies to date,⁷ and invokes only those European theorists of the last century who assigned this quicksilver category strictly to the history of religion, not the history of science. The typology it offers, moreover, on the basis of a confessedly arbitrary selection of 15 Arabic and two Persian authors from the ninth century to the twentieth, leaves the reader confused as to the actual, lived status of the various occult sciences within premodern Islamdom as a globalizing whole. Did anti-occultism polemicists like the theologian-jurist Ghazālī (d. 1111) and the historian-jurist Ibn Khaldūn (d. 1406)—those two darlings of modern Islamic studies—win the debate conclusively, or did

volume. At the same time, given that Western esotericism studies as currently constituted is heavily tilted toward the early modern and modern periods, and Islamic studies heavily tilted rather toward the medieval, this connection will not be obvious to scholars not already conversant with both literatures. Compounding this structural problem, the one scholar known to Islamicists and Europeanists alike, Henry Corbin, is precisely responsible for the phenomenological disappearance of Islamicate occultism into "Shi'i esotericism," here understood strictly as a timeless, apolitical, and *Aryan* category with little connection to historical "Islam," much less "the West." On the all-structuring scientism-religionism binary in Islamic studies, which has almost wholly occluded Islamicate occultism from Western intellectual and cultural history, see my forthcoming essay "Is (Islamic) Occult Science Science?"

6. On this theme see e.g. Matthew Melvin-Koushki, "(De)colonizing Early Modern Occult Philosophy," *Magic, Ritual, and Witchcraft* 12, no. 1 (2017): 98–112, esp. 112.

7. For such a diagnosis see my introduction to *Islamicate Occultism: New Perspectives*, "De-orienting the study of Islamicate Occultism."

their more numerous pro-occultist peers?⁸ Did such strident theological and legal rejections of certain occult sciences really discourage elite and popular investment in the same, whether in their own time or in the centuries after? Did Muslims, like Christians, orgiastically burn witches and their books? Were classical Arabic formulations simply slavishly repeated in other major Islamicate languages like Persian, Turkish, or Urdu? Did the epistemological and sociological status of these sciences shift over time and space? Is Islamic Magic only Religion, or can it also be Science?

This confusion, this reduction of Magic to Religion, dogs the volume as a whole. Indeed, some chapters go so far as to argue facetiously that “magic” was and is rejected in “Islam”; yet the majority show trenchantly that it was and is nevertheless ubiquitous in Islamicate societies—so ubiquitous, in fact, that even normative, orthodoxizing sources often treat matters occult as unproblematic and hence in merest passing.

The first argument is implied by Chapter 2, wherein Maher Jarrar offers a brief treatment of the perennially pressing theological need, in this case in eleventh-century Iraq, to distinguish legitimate prophetic miracles from magic and trickery, which are always illegal; his focus here is on the Muʿtazilī (rationalist) theologian Qāḍī ʿAbd al-Jabbār (d. 1025), as well as his Ashʿarī counterpart and fellow qadī Abū Bakr al-Bāqillānī (d. 1012). Jarrar also provides a translation of a relevant passage from the former’s *Ambiguous Verses of the Quran* (*Mutashābih al-Qurʾān*). Both worthies represent an entirely hostile perspective: they have no interest in, and do not acknowledge, the contemporary status of magic (*sihr*) as a standard natural science (*ʿilm ṭabīʿī*)—here exemplified by their earlier Iberian contemporary Maslama al-Qurṭubī’s (d. 964) seminal *Goal of the Sage* (*Ghāyat al-ḥakīm*), famed as the *Picatrix* in Europe—, and adduce it solely as a foil for their theology of miracles. Magic (used here in the most reductive, black-box sense) can only be unbelief, delusion, or deception. Suggestively, the chapter opens with a gesture toward those modern anthropological distinctions between Magic and Religion—there is no mention of Science—that would seem to be prefigured by these medieval theologians.

Similarly, in Chapter 3 Mahmoud Haggag surveys the theological-legal views on magic of four prominent Arabic scholars, from the ninth century to the fifteenth. They include the great Iraqi polymath Ibn Qutayba (d. 889), who in his book on traditional Arab astrometeorology, *Kitāb al-Anwāʾ*, characterizes various magical and divinatory practices, including astrology, as

8. To be clear, Ghazālī, unlike Ibn Khaldūn, was engaging rather in *intra-occultist* invective; my thanks to Nicholas Harris for this observation.

merely pre-Islamic paganism; the Iranian philosopher, alchemist, historian, and librarian Miskawayh (d. 1030), who, adopting a neutral position, distinguished between traditional divinatory techniques that tell the past from those that tell the future, and identified astrology as a natural science; the Egyptian lexicographer and chancery official Ibn Manẓūr (d. 1312), whose definition of *siḥr* (magic) in his landmark dictionary *Language of the Arabs* (*Lisān al-ʿarab*) associates the term with the central concept of “turning something into other than its proper state” (*ṣarf al-shayʿ ʿan ḥaqīqati-hi ilā ghayri-hi*), and hence encompassing everything from intercourse with demons and enchantment to the power of poetry and eloquence, i.e., “licit magic” (*siḥr ḥalāl*);⁹ and above all the now much-celebrated Ibn Khaldūn, who is openly, obsessively hostile, while nevertheless admitting to the scientific, if illegal, reality of magic and divination. The chapter ends by fast-forwarding to the (similarly hostile) position on magic in two modern national juristic summae, Egyptian and Kuwaiti respectively, together with that of the modern Egyptian-Qatari mufti Yūsuf al-Qaraḏāwī (b. 1926). Haggag concludes on the basis of this slim and cherrypicked evidence that *the majority of Muslims historically rejected magic*—a wildly antihistorical thesis the volume as a whole disproves. Most egregiously, the chapter opens by vaunting Ibn Khaldūn as the single greatest authority on Islamic Magic to have ever lived and depending on him throughout—no matter that the confused account of this Tunisian “father of sociology” is blatantly polemical and counterfactual.¹⁰

A stark departure from this abortive line of reasoning is represented by Chapter 4, wherein Hans Daiber presents five magical recipes for the discovery of thieves from Yemeni manuscripts copied between the seventeenth

9. What Haggag does not note is Ibn Manẓūr’s brief but revealing praise of al-Būnī in his dictionary’s introduction, wherein he “claims to have successfully experimented with letrist procedures” (Noah Gardiner, “The Occultist Encyclopedism of ʿAbd al-Raḥmān al-Biṣṭāmī,” *Mamlūk Studies Review* 20 [2017]: 3–38, esp. 11).

10. Ibn Khaldūn’s anti-occultist arguments—constituting a full *eleven percent* of his *Prolegomena* (*Muqaddima*)—are summarized and contextualized in Matthew Melvin-Koushki, “In Defense of Geomancy: Šaraf al-Dīn Yazdī Rebuts Ibn Ḥaldūn’s Critique of the Occult Sciences,” in *Islamicate Occultism*, ed. Melvin-Koushki and Gardiner, 346–403; Noah Gardiner, “Esotericism in a Manuscript Culture: Aḥmad al-Būnī and His Readers through the Mamlūk Period” (Ph.D. diss., University of Michigan, 2014), 300–21. Exemplifying the perils of relying so narrowly on the ill-informed Ibn Khaldūn is Haggag’s reflexive attribution of the *Ghāyat al-ḥakīm* to the Andalusian mathematician-astronomer Maslama al-Majrīṭī (d. 1007)—an attribution proven to be false over a century ago by Reinhart Dozy, and its correct authorship shown over two decades ago in Maribel Fierro, “Bāṭinism in al-Andalus. Maslama b. Qāsim al-Qurṭubī (d. 353/964), Author of the *Rutbat al-Ḥakīm* and the *Ghāyat al-Ḥakīm* (Pica-trix),” *Studia Islamica* 84, no. 2 (1996): 87–112.

and nineteenth centuries, providing translations of each. Their emphasis on specifically quranic knotting and blowing magic aside, he rightly holds them up as evidence for the continued mainstream status of *Neoplatonism* in particular as providing the indispensable theoretical mechanism for explaining occult causality through sympathy or correspondence (*tanāsūb*), thereby alleviating the theological tension between divine predestination and human free will, on the one hand, and divine transcendence and omnipresence, on the other. Daiber provides a brief but masterful survey of the incorporation of this mechanism in early Islamic thought, even by Ashʿarī theologians like Ghazālī; he concludes with al-Kindī's (d. 873) emanationist theory of magic, formulated in his *De radiis* (the Arabic original is lost), as an especially explicit and influential instance of the same. Thus contextualized (though the leap from the ninth century to the seventeenth is disconcerting), these Yemeni texts suggest the early modern ubiquity of specifically Neoplatonic forms of occultism well beyond the imperial metropolises and well through the colonial era—an exciting thesis indeed, given the sharp contrast it cuts to contemporary Christianate developments. But Daiber's conclusion on this basis that “magic” and “religion” are inseparable, while obviously legitimate in the case of quranic magic, nevertheless has the unfortunate (and surely unintended) effect of excluding Neoplatonic philosophy from the history of science.

A more blatant assumption that Magic can only be Religion and never Science drives Chapter 5, wherein Lutz Richter-Bernburg argues for the increasing displacement of Galenic medicine by Prophetic, which is to say magical, medicine; this “de-scientization” allowed medicine as a discipline to become naturalized in Islamdom in a way that merely pagan Greek medicine could not have been. This positivist argument, of course, simply reproduces that of Ullmann, who lamented the pernicious and perverting effect of magic on “real” medicine.¹¹ That Galenic medicine (*ṭibb*) too was often technically magical, and hence routinely classified by Arabic and Persian encyclopedists as an occult science, is here simply ignored as inconvenient to this thesis.¹² And yet again, Ibn Khaldūn—together with his fellow anti-occultist polemicist Ibn Qayyim al-Jawziyya (d. 1350), a theologian-jurist and strict puritan—is bizarrely cited as ultimate authority on this magico-medical matter, with which he exhibits little familiarity.¹³

11. Lemay, “L'Islam historique,” 20. Cf. Irmeli Perho's contrary argument in *The Prophet's Medicine: A Creation of the Muslim Traditionalist Scholars* (Helsinki: Finnish Oriental Society, 1995); my thanks to Nicholas Harris for this reference.

12. Melvin-Koushki, “Powers of One.”

13. Idem, “In Defense,” 366–68. Most notably, Ibn al-Qayyim went so far as to

Ursula Bsees's Chapter 6 treats of the earliest surviving Arabic papyri on magic, which—despite the pronounced classico- and arabocentrism of Islamic studies, and despite their indispensability for the social history of early Islam—have remained almost entirely unstudied to date. (Testifying to the same distaste for magic on the part of modern researchers, even magical papyri from the Cairo Geniza, especially those of a more “Islamic” stamp, are routinely downplayed or disregarded.¹⁴) She takes as case study and transcribes a ninth-century papyrus preserved in the Austrian National Library—one whose formulae, crucially, suggest revealing comparisons with the *Goal of the Sage*. Most importantly, this text is evidence for an extremely early use of quranic letter magic, inspired by the model of the mysterious disconnected sura-initial letters (*muqattaʿāt*), which corroborates Shiʿi sources in particular. Yet its Egyptian provenance suggests it to be also dependent on Greek and Coptic sources; the possibility that Coptic magic may well have been influenced by Arabic magic in turn makes this category an especially rich nexus of cross-cultural transmission. Similarly, Bsees's acknowledgement of the difficulty in distinguishing between ritual prayer and magic proper is even more salient for later, much more sophisticated lettrist practice. Is the mere presence of a quranic passage or *muqattaʿāt* in such a context enough to determine whether a given prayer is merely religious or in fact magical, or is such a determination simply impossible?¹⁵

blame the Mongol conquest of Islamdom on the contemporary florescence of occult science and Avicennism in tandem; his desperate polemics, which reduce occultism to Ismaʿilism, paganism and peripatetic philosophy, are a likely model for Ibn Khaldūn's. At the same time, and due precisely to his fervent opposition to Hellenic philosophy, Ibn al-Qayyim was a strong and particularly influential advocate for Prophetic medicine against Galenic (my thanks to Nūkheth Varlık for this observation).

14. For a survey and critique of the state of the field, see Gideon Bohak, “Prolegomena to the Study of the Jewish Magical Tradition,” *Currents in Biblical Research* 8, no. 1 (2009): 107–50. While massive lacunae remain, however, Bohak's account throws into high relief the equally massive disproportionality in the study of Jewish vs. Islamic “magic”: significantly more Judaicists than Islamicists are currently invested in its study, and the former have edited and studied many more relevant texts and artifacts than have the latter. And nowhere is this disproportionality enshrined more than in the study of the twin sciences of kabbalah and lettrism: the first is an academic industry in its own right, while the study of the second remains in its infancy—despite the fact that many more lettrist texts have come down to us than kabbalist.

15. Cf. Michael Dols's definition of Islamic magic as “supercharged prayer” (“The Theory of Magic in Healing,” reprinted in *Magic and Divination*, ed. Savage-Smith, 87).

A similar documentary intervention is made by Johannes Thomann in Chapter 7, who surveys a wide range of magical texts produced between the seventh and fifteenth centuries, with emphasis on Egyptian papyri and paper documents. They variously include instances of quranic letter magic, divine names magic, and foreign (gibberish) word magic; sigils and circular writing; magic squares; block-printed amulets; horoscope diagrams; and geomancy. That these disciplines and/or their formal conventions hail from different parts of Afro-Eurasia, from China to Iran to the Mediterranean, testifies again to the great value of the occult sciences in the study of premodern cross-cultural processes. I do, however, have two quibbles. Thomann's assumption that the magic square (*wafq al-aʿdād*) only appears in Arabic in the tenth century, and (like square horoscopes) can only have been transmitted from China, is both incorrect and premature; they appear already in the ninth century, as new research has shown, and India too may have been a source.¹⁶ Similarly, his parallel contention that geomancy (*ʿilm al-raml*), Arabic cognate to the *I Ching*, could have only come from China—solely because Fakhr al-Dīn Rāzī (d. 1210) describes it in his unprecedentedly comprehensive Persian encyclopedia of the sciences as being a *gharīb* or “foreign” science—is implausible; it ignores the fact that intellectual genealogies of this science in Arabic and Persian manuals thereof presuppose a pre-Islamic Near Eastern and/or Indian origin, as well as an early Berber connection. To the contrary, the Iranian philosopher-encyclopedist uses this descriptor to make the relatively novel Arabic science of geomancy—which he significantly assigns to the mathematical sciences—legible to a new twelfth-century persophone audience, for whom *ʿulūm-i gharība* (“the rarely mastered sciences”) was simply the standard Persian designation for the occult sciences (*al-ʿulūm al-khafiyya*) as a natural-mathematical subset.¹⁷

In Chapter 8, Tobias Nünlist too pursues a codicological and art-historical project, investigating so-called amulet scrolls (Amulettrollen) produced between the fourteenth and twentieth centuries. He shows persuasively that they are best classed into three distinctive types: Arabic (Mamluk-Ottoman), Persian (Timurid-Turkmen), and Turkish (Ottoman). But Nünlist seeks to disenchant (entzaubern) the genre, arguing that, unlike much simpler and cheaper popular amulets (sometimes block-printed), these scrolls are only

16. See Bink Hallum, “New Light on Early Arabic *Awfaq* Literature,” forthcoming in *Islamicate Occult Sciences*, ed. Saif, Leoni, Melvin-Koushki and Yahya.

17. Melvin-Koushki, “Powers of One”; idem, “Persianate Geomancy from Tūsī to the Millennium: A Preliminary Survey,” in *The Occult Sciences*, ed. El-Bizri and Orthmann, 151–99.

incidentally magical; their contents are rather generally “religious” in nature, inasmuch as they comprise devotional texts popular among heterodox groups, and especially sufi orders and chivalric (*futuwwa*) brotherhoods. (The Bektāshīyya and perhaps even the anarchic Ḥurūfiyya may have been involved.) As with Bsees’s similar caution, this is a potentially important analytical distinction to bear in mind. At the same time, we as modern Euro-American researchers must become much more comfortable than we currently are with the frequent ambiguity and even outright contradictoriness of our sources, lest we inadvertently overdraw boundaries that for our historical actors were much more fluid, contested, and even nonexistent—especially in matters occult.¹⁸ And we certainly must not claim to have *disenchanted* our sources, whether magical or not: this is merely to replace their mythic worldview with our own, is to reprise the mechanics of magic-obsessed colonialism.¹⁹

In Chapter 9, Fabian Käs shows that occult-scientific content may well be lurking in the most unsuspected of genres by the thirteenth century—in this case hunting manuals. As a case in point, he presents the hunting and falconry manual of the veterinarian Ibn Qushtimur (d. 1269), *The Clear Canon for Treating Predators* (*al-Qānūn al-wāḍiḥ fī mu‘ālaġāt al-jawāriḥ*), which includes astrological calculations for identifying good hunting days and times; these are edited and translated here and their textual sources tentatively identified. Contemporary and later polemic aside, election astrology (*ikhtiyārāt*), an innovation specific to Arabic, was thus unproblematically incorporated into various genres not usually associated with the occult sciences, testifying to their increasingly mainstream status in elite and popular culture alike.

Christian Mauder’s pivotal Chapter 10 expands temporally and geographically on this argument with respect to a different but equally practical genre: the *ḥisba* manual. Meant for the training and regulation of market inspectors (sg. *muḥtasib*), these manuals likewise testify to the sweeping desoterization of the occult sciences in Egypt particularly and the Islamicate world generally during the fourteenth century, when astrology, amuletry, and

18. On this theme more broadly, see Shahab Ahmed, *What Is Islam? The Importance of Being Islamic* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2015); Thomas Bauer, *Die Kultur der Ambiguität: eine andere Geschichte des Islams* (Berlin: Verlag der Weltreligionen, 2011).

19. See Jason Ā. Josephson-Storm, *The Myth of Disenchantment: Magic, Modernity, and the Birth of the Human Sciences* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2017); cf. Brian Moeran and Timothy de Waal Malefyt, eds., *Magical Capitalism: Enchantment, Spells, and Occult Practices in Contemporary Economies* (Cham, Switzerland: Palgrave Macmillan, 2018).

various other forms of magic and divination became much more visible as social practices and hence in need of public regulation. The evidence Mauder marshals here conclusively invalidates the common assumption in the literature that the occult sciences could not be within the *muḥtasib*'s remit because their practice was very rarely carried out in public—due, naturally, to theologico-legal prohibitions of the kind sketched in earlier chapters. This assumption is supported by the absence of references to the occult sciences in theoretical or dogmatic formulations of the office as that offered by Ibn Khaldūn (of course!) and others. But such tendentious abstractions can hardly be expected to reflect everyday lived realities. Here we must turn rather to chancery texts, such as the Mamluk secretary al-Qalqashandī's (d. 1418) monumental *Dawn to the Nightblind: On the Art of Writing* (*Ṣubḥ al-aʿshā fī ṣināʿat al-inshāʾ*), which puts astrology firmly within the remit of market inspectors. And the occult sciences are even more visible in *ḥisba* manuals themselves, often written by actual holders of that office and hence far more reflective of contemporary social practice. That practice, as it turns out, was frequently occult. In support of this thesis, Mauder presents five major such manuals produced between the eleventh to fourteenth centuries, from Iberia to Egypt to India, which discuss divination, magic, astrology, and amuletry both frankly and neutrally; some even require that the practitioners of such arts move their businesses from side streets to main, the better to be policed. The overriding legal concern in all these manuals is that the general public not be misled or cheated, and that the sexes not improperly mix. Significantly, they propose no restrictions whatsoever on occult-scientific practice by scholarly elites. Needless to say, such evidence for widespread charlatanry is hardly proof of the marginal or esoteric nature of occultism in Islamicate societies of the post-Mongol and post-Black Death era—rather the reverse. Magical abuses must of course be combated, like any other. Henceforth, however, all theologico-legal prohibitions of magic are simply to be disregarded as irrelevant, as mere puritanical wishful thinking, in the face of the overwhelming social reality that is Islamicate occult science.

After four centuries of vigorous debate, in sum, the defenders of magic seem to have definitively won, and its detractors to have lost: there are no sustained anti-occultist polemics in Arabic (much less Persian) after that of the puritan Ibn Khaldūn. The reasons for this early modern intra-Western cultural divergence are as yet unclear; but the fact remains that Muslims, unlike Christians, simply did not burn witches or their books.²⁰

20. Melvin-Koushki, "Powers of One," 128–29; idem, "How to Rule the World: Occult-Scientific Manuals of the Early Modern Persian Cosmopolis," *Journal of Persianate Studies* 11, no. 2 (2018): 140–54; cf. Emily Savage-Smith, "Introduction:

If occultism was increasingly *de-esotericized* from the twelfth century onward, it was also conclusively *sanctified* (this through association with sufism), a pivotal phenomenon peculiar to the twelfth to fourteenth-century Mediterranean zone as a whole.²¹ The primary node of these two paradigm shifts was lettrism (*‘ilm al-ḥurūf*, aka *‘ilm al-asmā’*) in particular—Hebrew kabbalah’s coeval Arabic twin—now reconceptualized as a scientific means of harnessing the sacral power (*walāya*) of the Imams and the saints; the Quran and the divine names it reveals now became the preferred media for magic. In Chapter 11, Dorothee Pielow offers an account of these two interdependent historical processes, with a focus on letter magic (*‘ilm al-sīmiyā’*), unusually translated here as “the science of the [divine] names” (348).²² Given their sweeping sociopolitical implications over the subsequent centuries, however, it is unfortunate that she chooses to take a strictly ahistorical approach. Pielow does not seem to be aware that her main source, the *Great Sun of Knowledge* (*Shams al-ma‘ārif al-kubrā*), the most influential Arabic grimoire ever produced, cannot be attributed to the sufi-mage Aḥmad al-Būnī (d. btw. 1225–33), but is rather a much later compilation and accretion around an original Būnian core, as Noah Gardiner (whom she cites) has conclusively shown.²³ (She is nevertheless correct that this grimoire epitomizes the two processes in question.) Similarly, Pielow cites the fifteenth-century Ḥurūfiyya—an anarchic sufi group anathematized by contemporary lettrists—as mainstream representatives of this science, passing over its far more respectable scholarly

Magic and Divination in Early Islam,” in *Magic and Divination*, ed. idem, xiii. This is not to suggest that such polemic did not persist thereafter in some fashion, only that it was far more limited in scope, and rarely fatal for the accused. Thus astrology, for example, that queen of the occult sciences, was sometimes singled out for criticism by Ottoman scholars, and especially sufis, as implying astral determinism—yet concurrently institutionalized at the Ottoman court to an unprecedented and unparalleled extent; see A. Tunç Şen, “Astrology in the Service of the Empire: Knowledge, Prognostication, and Politics at the Ottoman Court, 1450s–1550s” (Ph.D. diss., University of Chicago, 2016).

21. On both processes see e.g. Gardiner, “Occultist Encyclopedism”; idem, “Esotericist Reading Communities and the Early Circulation of the Sufi Occultist Aḥmad al-Būnī’s Works,” in *Islamicate Occultism*, ed. Melvin-Koushki and Gardiner, 405–41; Liana Saif, “From *Gāyat al-ḥakīm* to *Šams al-ma‘ārif*: Ways of Knowing and Paths of Power in Medieval Islam,” in *ibid.*, 297–345.

22. As Ullmann notes, *sīmiyā’* seemingly derives from Greek *semeia* (pl. of *semeion*, “sign”) via Syriac, denoting its frequent association with the manipulation of letters (*Natur- und Geheimwissenschaften*, 361–62). But its meaning is unstable; in the early modern Persianate context, for instance, *sīmiyā* often refers rather to illusionism (*‘ilm al-khayālāt*).

23. Gardiner, “Esotericism.”

exponents in silence.²⁴ That her citation of Ibn Khaldūn as an authority on this matter is likewise cripplingly problematic should now go without saying. Most problematically, such ahistorical cherry-picking then allows for the total identification of “mysticism” and “magic”; when, where, and for whom this identification applies is not specified. These caveats aside, however, I full-throatedly second Pielow’s suggestion that lettrism and kabbalah must finally be studied in tandem as the twin sciences they are.

Continuing the same focus on lettrism, Eva Orthmann’s Chapter 12 moves to an examination of this sanctified science as theorized and practiced in sixteenth-century Mughal India. To this end, she takes as representative case study Muḥammad Ghawth Gwāliyārī’s (d. 1563) *Five Gems* (*al-Jawāhir al-khams*), a Persian manual of letter and astral magic that boasted both Arabic and Urdu translations and several commentaries; it has remained one of the most widely used grimoires in South Asia to the present. Like Pseudo-Būnī’s *Great Sun of Knowledge*, it stands testament to the total fusion of astrology and lettrism by the early modern period, as well as the total sanctification of the latter: for Gwāliyārī was a leading Shaṭṭārī sufi master with close ties to the ruling elite. The *Five Gems* is thus an index of the epistemic and sociopolitical sea change in Islamicate occult-scientific theory and practice between the medieval and early modern periods, as a comparison to such earlier classics of the genre as Fakhr al-Dīn Rāzī’s *Hidden Secret* (*al-Sirr al-maktūm*) and Maslama al-Qurṭubī’s *Goal of the Sage*, from which divine names magic is entirely absent, conclusively shows.²⁵ (The brief reference to Ibn Khaldūn on this point does no damage to the argument.) As Orthmann persuasively concludes, the popularity of Gwāliyārī’s grimoire was ensured by its reflection of contemporary Persianate practice, as well as its systematic, user-friendly structure. Equally important are her brief opening and closing observations that such occult-scientific manuals could not but be attractive to rulers in particular, given that they promise control over one’s political and military

24. On those exponents, see e.g. Melvin-Koushki, “The New Brethren of Purity: Ibn Turka and the Renaissance of Neopythagoreanism in the Early Modern Persian Cosmopolis,” in *Companion to the Reception of Pythagoras and Pythagoreanism*, ed. Aurélien Robert, Irene Caiazzo, and Constantin Macris, 2 vols. (Leiden: Brill, 2019), forthcoming; Gardiner, “Occultist Encyclopedism.”

25. Saïf, “From *Gāyat al-ḥakīm*.” On both seminal grimoires see Živa Vesel, “Le *Sirr al-Maktūm* de Fakhr al-Dīn Rāzī (m. 606H/1210) face à la *Ghāyat al-Ḥakīm*,” in *Images et magie. Picatrix entre orient et occident*, ed. Jean-Patrice Boudet, Anna Caiozzo, and Nicolas Weill-Parot (Paris: Honoré Champion, 2011), 77–93; and Michael Noble’s study of *Hidden Secret* forthcoming from de Gruyter in 2020.

fate. Mughal war magic, this is, unlike both Abbasid and Mongol, was prosecuted on the basis of the quranic divine names astrologically invoked and talismanically harnessed. (Can war technologies be “mystical”?) That this thesis is absent from the rest of the volume, however, is a lacuna that I, as an Islamicist specializing in precisely the intersection of occultism and imperialism, find especially glaring. Christian Magic is routinely identified with Empire; why is Islamic Magic not?²⁶

In Chapter 13, Ulrich Marzolph turns to matters more literary than lettrist, with a focus on the *Thousand and One Nights* (*Alf layla wa-layla*). As we all know from Disney’s *Aladdin*, this historically constantly evolving masterpiece of precisely *spellbinding* Arabic storytelling is frequently magical. Its episodes feature the mischief of jinn, magically induced travel, invisibility spells, and human transformations, especially into animals; various grimoires are cited with reverence, and various objects with occult properties are described, including apples, herbs, jewels, lamps, mirrors, swords, carpets, and especially rings, associated with the signet ring of the biblical-quranic Prophet-King-Mage Solomon. The theological emphasis throughout is on magic as surest proof of divine omnipotence and direct agency in human events. As Marzolph shows, however, a change in attitudes toward magic can be traced chronologically through this cycle’s evolution: earlier strata profess a very rudimentary theory of magic, while later strata tend toward theologically rationalizing its practice—further evidence for the ascendancy of occultism to mainstream status by the early modern period, and indeed for the emergence of what might be called a *lettrary* culture.²⁷

The final three chapters leap to the present, analyzing a variety of current magical discourses from comparative-literary, material-cultural, and anthropological perspectives. Susanne Enderwitz (Chapter 14) takes up the theme of magic in the modern Arabic novel, specifically of the fantasy and science fiction genres. Before moving to her case studies, Enderwitz traces the trajectory of Arabic magical realism, beginning in the 1970s, with explicit roots in the *Thousand and One Nights*, as well as in Gabriel García Márquez’s (d. 2014) *One Hundred Years of Solitude* and similar novels. Here art and literature are

26. For an early modern intra-Western comparison on this theme, see my study *The Occult Science of Empire in Aqqyunlu-Safavid Iran: Two Shirazi Lettrists and Their Manuals of Magic* (Leiden: Brill, forthcoming). One example among many of Europeanist arguments in this direction, on Francis Bacon (d. 1626) and British imperialism, is John Henry, *Knowledge Is Power: How Magic, the Government and an Apocalyptic Vision Helped Francis Bacon to Create Modern Science* (London: Icon Books, 2002).

27. I propose this term in Melvin-Koushki, “The New Brethren.”

reconceived as a magical space; the artist's muse is a modernized genie, and her art a mystical practice. Enderwitz identifies early- and mid-twentieth-century Arabic (especially Egyptian) literature as a transitional species in which both magic and mysticism were initially explored as ubiquitous social realities (as in Taha Hussein's [d. 1973] celebrated autobiography, *The Days [al-Ayyām]*)—then both comprehensively rejected in favor of positivist and reformist social realism. It was only when sufism and magic had lost much of their wonted prominence in Egyptian society that novelists again began to treat them seriously, but now nostalgically. (Naguib Mahfouz [d. 2006] was here a bridge.) In the second half of the twentieth century, sufism and magic were regularly invoked, and writing again experienced as a form of possession. Arabic entries in the “new genres” followed; but these are almost unstudied. Enderwitz presents the 2013 Saudi novel *ḤWJN*, by Ibrāhīm ‘Abbās (Ibraheem Abbas) and Yāsir Bahjat (Yasser Bahjatt), as emblematic of this process: for it synthesizes three genres—romance, fantasy, and sci-fi—to argue for the existence of jinn based on the expressly *scientific* proof of the Quran. The implied syllogism: 1) Islam is a rational religion; 2) the Quran asserts the existence of jinn; therefore 3) their existence can in principle and will be proven by science. Such novels both look backward and look forward to the realization of a postmaterialist techno-magical modernity.

In Chapter 15, Khanna Omarkhali and Anke Joisten-Pruschke provide an unprecedented anthropological and material-cultural account of the ritual use of magic bowls among Yazidis specifically and Muslim Kurds generally during the last two decades, based on Omarkhali's recent fieldwork with Yazidi *pīrs* in Armenia and Iraq. Magic bowls, of course, are well known to historians of late antiquity; the specimens in question perhaps represent a continuation of ancient Egyptian and Minoan practice, though in this case Assyrian-Babylonian precedent is more likely. As that may be, they are abundantly documented for the western part of the Sasanid Empire in particular, and were in regular use from China to the Atlantic. In the Hellenic sphere, their ritual efficacy was theorized in terms of *Neoplatonic theurgy*. The advent of Islam did not interrupt this tradition in the slightest; indeed, an increased emphasis was placed on healing, curse, protection, and love magic. But only three hundred out of over fifteen hundred surviving specimens (a conservative estimate) have been studied to date. Contemporary Yazidi and Muslim Kurdish magic bowls and their ritual use thus testify to the remarkable durability of this particular magical practice over millennia and vast distances—as well as to the equally remarkable evolution, both convergent and divergent, of such practices in different religio-cultural contexts. As a case in point: In general Kurdish Muslim use, magic bowls are used mainly for healing,

conception, and childbirth. Yazidis use them for these purposes as well, adding thereto protection against the evil eye and exorcism; but they have developed further distinctive magical rites, centered on these bowls as primary vehicles of priestly blessing for ill and hale alike. The bowls are filled with water and consecrated (no one may touch a bowl thus consecrated without prior ritual preparation, at the risk of going temporarily blind); during regular ritual use all present must drink thereof, communally partaking in the sanctity of the *pîrs*. As such, Yazidi magic bowls provide an invaluable but long ignored window onto a living ritual magical tradition—one that can boast both unusually deep historical roots and a creative new flowering in the present.

Finally, Johanna Schott's Chapter 16 turns a similarly comparative anthropological lens on popular magical practices in North Africa and West Africa respectively; while regional forms naturally vary, she concludes that they all exemplify and constitute an "economy of fear." White and especially black magic are very much social realities, both as means of direct control and currencies of social power. The overriding fixation is on diagnosing, deflecting, or deploying causes of evil and harm, this through the offices of malevolent or benevolent spirits or mages, who are to be pacified or paid to work on one's behalf. A greater emphasis is placed on the cult of the saints and the use of trance dances for healing in North Africa than in West Africa, as well as a greater preoccupation with letter magic on the one hand and with ghosts, jinn, and the evil eye on the other; West Africans emphasize rather the manufacture and sale of magic medicines, as well as oracles like the chicken oracle. Likewise, damaging magic is used by North Africans more often as a tool for social climbing, and by West Africans as a source for financial gain.²⁸ Common to both cultural contexts, however, is a dependence on animal sacrifice and a fear of ghosts as a cause of disease. Most importantly, the use of magic, Schott argues, cuts across all social strata, whether urban or rural, educated or illiterate; and anxiety as to magical attack has led to a prevalence of professional mages—many of whom are technologically savvy.

To this reviewer at least, the picture thus painted is dark and pathological; and to the extent that picture might be accurate, the rupturous role of French and British colonialism in creating disturbed societies—true economies of

28. On the cognate uses of Islamicate occult science—often recast in New Age or other frameworks—as tools for politicking, social climbing, romance, and financial gain in the Islamic Republic of Iran, see Alireza Doostdar, *The Iranian Metaphysicals: Explorations in Science, Islam, and the Uncanny* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2018).

fear and loathing—in North and West Africa is not adequately addressed.²⁹ Unlike the previous chapter, moreover, Schott's observations are based not on personal fieldwork, but rather on existing secondary literature in European languages—much of it quite dated indeed, and some even overtly colonialist. In particular, to frame her data she relies, astonishingly, on the British social anthropologist Edward R. Leach's 1964 definition of magic, based on his fieldwork in South Asia, that condemns it as an essentially anti-empirical and hence doomed attempt at control of one's environment, which excludes magic equally from religion and from science.³⁰ With such a premise, based on neither direct experience, theoretical awareness, historical insight, nor philological expertise, Schott's outsider, "objective" narrative strays uncomfortably close to arguing for the *superstitiousness*, and hence *unmodernity*, of the fearful Moslem magical natives. Nevertheless: this chapter joins most of the volume's case studies to show the ubiquity of "magic" in early modern and modern Islamicate societies, even through the colonial rupture, all theologico-legal prohibitions—Arabic or French—be damned.



This brings us to Bernd-Christian Otto's concluding essay, "Magic in Islam: A Discourse-Historical Perspective," which, again, as the editors state, serves as indispensable theoretical framing for the volume as a whole.³¹ Most importantly, it makes these Islamicate materials analytically legible to Europeanist historians of "Western learned magic" (*westlicher Gelehrtenmagie*), and shows the prevailing, purely Eurocentric account thereof to be fatally amputated—a diagnosis with which I strenuously agree. For Islam, of course, in terms of cultural genetics, is historically the greater part of the West; it spread the Hellenic-Abrahamic synthesis over a vaster and more populous part of the Afro-Eurasian ecumene than did Christianity and Judaism combined.³² Given this cultural-genetic continuity, therefore, we should expect

29. Cf. Savage-Smith, "Introduction," xvi.

30. On Leach's outmoded approach to "magic" more generally, see Bernd-Christian Otto and Michael Stausberg, eds., *Defining Magic: A Reader* (Sheffield: Equinox, 2013), ch. 20.

31. More broadly, see Otto's *Magie: rezeptions- und diskursgeschichtliche Analysen von der Antike bis zur Neuzeit* (Berlin: De Gruyter, 2011); idem, "Historicizing 'Western Learned Magic,'" *Aries* 16 (2016): 161–240.

32. For intellectual-historical purposes, the West is best defined as *the half of Afro-Eurasia west of South India*, incorporating the *Arabic, Persian, and Latin cosmopolises*, that vast realm where the *Hellenic-Abrahamic synthesis* reigned supreme, and philosophy came to be pursued in *mathematical-linguistic* terms; see Matthew Melvin-Koushki,

Islamicate and Christianate discourses on magic to converge and diverge in instructive ways. And indeed they did (and do). But only a *discourse-historical* approach, Otto argues, is adequate to this pressing comparative task: for “magic” is an exceptionally problematic term, a floating signifier exceedingly difficult to pin down, a honeyed trap into which the essentialist will always fall.³³ Whether in Arabic or Persian, German or English, *siḥr/jādū/Magic/magic* as a terminally contested emic category is simply useless for etic purposes (a rule unfortunately violated by several chapters in *Secrets*).

This is not to say, however, that no larger patterns of emic usage can be discerned. As Otto contends to the contrary, historical discourses on “magic” fall more or less neatly into *insider* or protagonist and *outsider* or antagonist camps. Insider discourses, as we might expect, are highly dynamic over time and space, and directly responsive to new cultural and material contexts; that is, they *evolve*. But outsider discourses do not: they remain fairly static over many centuries, and rarely reflect actual contemporary theory or practice.

As a non-Europeanist, I cannot comment on the general applicability of this discourse-historical model to Christianate developments;³⁴ but it would seem to fit what little we currently know of the Islamicate data rather well. Thus in all the major Arabic and Persian classifications of the sciences (sg. *taṣnīf al-ʿulūm*) produced from the twelfth century onward—which are, *without exception*, heavily pro-occultist—the occult sciences are constantly shifted between the natural, mathematical, and religious sciences, depending on local

“*Tahqīq* vs. *Taqlīd* in the Renaissances of Western Early Modernity,” *Philological Encounters* 3, nos. 1–2 (2018): 193–249.

33. Otto identifies Hanegraaff’s *Esotericism and the Academy* as a masterpiece of precisely this approach, despite the latter’s reservations (“Discourse Theory Trumps Discourse Theory: Wouter Hanegraaff’s *Esotericism and the Academy*,” *Religion* 43, no. 2 [2013]: 231–40). Cf. Hanegraaff’s response in the same issue, which insists rather—quite rightly!—on the subordination of theory to history (“The Power of Ideas: Esotericism, Historicism, and the Limits of Discourse,” *Religion* 43, no. 2 [2013]: 252–73). For the broader context of this debate, see e.g. Egil Asprem, “Beyond the West: Towards a New Comparativism in the Study of Esotericism,” *Correspondences* 2, no. 1 (2014): 3–33.

34. For a Europeanist critique of this approach—one rightly emphasizing the historical permeability of insider and outsider camps, and the consequent methodological need for more ambiguous emic-etic and insider-outsider definitions—see Claire Fanger’s response to Otto’s similarly programmatic essay “A Discourse Historical Approach towards Medieval Learned Magic,” both in *The Routledge History of Medieval Magic*, ed. Sophie Page and Catherine Rider (London: Routledge, 2019), at 64–67 (esp. 64) and 37–47 respectively.

context.³⁵ And thus the perennial tendency in Muslim anti-occultist arguments, following Christian and Jewish models, to reiterate the same three core allegations, always centered on the same essentializing conception of “magic”: it is ineffective, that is, anti-scientific; it is anti-religious; it is anti-social. In particular, Muslim polemicists inherit, reproduce, and elaborate on Jewish and Christian *demonological* stereotypes, which have proven to be remarkably stable over two millennia—indeed, they run like a red thread even through modern Christian colonialist and Euro-American anthropological discourse. To invert Tolstoy’s formulation: *Unhappy magical families are all alike; every happy magical family is happy in its own way.*

Secrets tells the epic tale of the happy and unhappy magical families of Islam in equal measure; Pseudo-Būnī and Ibn Khaldūn—its two most-cited authors by far—epitomize both camps respectively. But as I have argued, and as Otto concurs, the latter’s naked hostility to the subject under study must surely disqualify him as an authority on the same.³⁶ Yet the introduction and no less than four chapters in the volume unproblematically cite him as such (Mauder’s chapter is here the exception); others similarly favor antagonists over protagonists without justifying this choice. As Otto’s typology suggests, however, to rely on Ibn Khaldūnian and other outsider discourses on “magic” to define the scope of its historical and anthropological study is to dance with the devil that is essentialism, is to forfeit the possibility of understanding the myriad ways in which Muslims have theorized and lived occult science from the seventh century to the postcolonial present.

It is also to reflexively project the early modern Christianate experience onto the Islamicate. For in the former, insularist, Latin European context the outsider camp often achieved political and legal dominance, sometimes violently; so many bodies and books were burnt that much of our knowledge of Christianate popular occultism comes rather from the many manuals written to counter it, the *Hammer of Witches* (*Malleus malificarum*) of 1486 most notorious among them.³⁷ To be sure, such Latinate witch-hunting was largely directed at nonelites and nonpractitioners of magic, especially women, and often explicitly exempted scholarly forms of natural magic from persecution; it thus coincided with the high point of occult philosophy and occult science

35. I track these classificatory shifts in Arabic and Persian encyclopedias of the sciences, from the tenth century to the seventeenth, in Melvin-Koushki, “Powers of One.”

36. Ibid.; idem, “In Defense.”

37. Richard Kieckhefer, *Forbidden Rites: A Necromancer’s Manual of the Fifteenth Century*, University Park: Pennsylvania State University Press, 1998, 1–8.

in the Latinate tradition. But this coincidence was nevertheless a fraught one. Here Heinrich Cornelius Agrippa (d. 1535), author of the seminal *Three Books of Occult Philosophy* (*De philosophia occulta libri tres*), is a case in point: the German humanist-theologian's famous and successful defense in 1519 of a woman accused of witchcraft only earned him the lasting ire of the Inquisition.³⁸ This tension, moreover, was part and parcel of the larger cultural crisis that was the Renaissance. Not only were humanist scholars forced to be more circumspect in and apologetic of their interest in the occult sciences than was previously necessary; many also overcompensated by actively polemicizing against the very Arabic (and sometimes even Hebrew) sources that made Latinate high occultism possible.³⁹ This culture of suppression, common to outsider and insider camps alike, eventually succeeded, if only partially, in rendering esotericist discourses a primary form of *rejected knowledge*—a status it retains in the modern Euro-American academy.⁴⁰

But the same declinist narrative simply does not hold for the contemporary Islamicate and especially Persianate world: Muslim outsider scholars, despite an equal earnestness and equal social capital, seem rather to have comprehensively failed in their puritanical project over the long term. The ravings of the likes of Ibn Khaldūn—that would-be hammer of witches and burner of books—could thus be and were simply ignored by courtly and scholarly elites as incompatible with imperial scientific cosmopolitanism; cunning women and men knew themselves to be safe from the inquisitorial pyre, and plied their occult arts so publicly that charlatans too came to abound and had to be policed. Only the Christian and Soviet colonization of the Islamicate world finally managed to force the necessary social, economic and hence epistemic ruptures that would allow for the Protestantization of Islam too: an unholy alliance of colonialists, orientalist, and Muslim scripturalists together loudly reasserted the outsider definition of magic as the only truly *Islamic* one—an antihistorical polemic inherited by Islamicist scholarship from its orientalist inception, Ibn Khaldūnian to the core.⁴¹ (The *Index Islamicus* suggests that

38. Vittoria Perrone Compagni, “Heinrich Cornelius Agrippa von Nettesheim,” *The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* (Spring 2017 edition), ed. Edward N. Zalta (2017), online: <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/agrippa-nettesheim>. Accessed September 4, 2019.

39. On such humanist anti-Arabism see Dag Nikolaus Hasse, *Success and Suppression: Arabic Sciences and Philosophy in the Renaissance* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2016); Melvin-Koushki, “*Tahqīq* vs. *Taqlīd*.”

40. Here the definitive study is, again, Hanegraaff, *Esotericism and the Academy*; see also Josephson-Storm, *The Myth of Disenchantment*.

41. On this colonizing process in what would become Soviet Central Asia—as well as the use of occult science as a primary means of anti-colonial resistance—see

more ink has been spilled to date on that Mālikī hanging judge alone *than all of the Islamicate occult sciences combined*.) And yet the anthropologists tell us: Islamic Magic continues to flourish even in those regions most violently colonized, albeit in colorful, creative, and hybridizing new forms.⁴² It is to this alternative trajectory of Western high occultism over the *longue durée* that the bulk of *Secrets* attests.

The comparatively socially and epistemically open, economically flourishing, and cosmopolitan environment offered by many premodern Islamicate imperial societies thus made possible a wide range of occult-scientific advances, some of which were eagerly taken up in a much more insular and decidedly postimperial Latin Christendom. From his perspective as a Europeanist, Otto usefully identifies those specifically Islamicate technologies and techniques that had the most dramatic impact on Christianate magical theory and practice. Astrological talismans, ritually activated, were by far the most important such innovation; the *Goal of the Sage*, whence the *Picatrix*, provided the first comprehensive system of correspondences across multiple ontological categories as a rigorous scientific basis for talisman production. Similarly, its requirement that the image of the celestial body in question be engraved thereon serves to distinguish the tenth-century Arabic talisman from much more rudimentary Egyptian and Greek precedents. *Nīranjāt*, or natural-magical mixtures based on alchemical principles, applied to the human body and activated by means of their names, likewise became popular—but still remained rather mysterious to Latin scholars, whose available translation of Ibn Sīnā's *On the Divisions of the Rational Sciences* (*Risāla fī Aqsām al-'ulūm al-'aqliyya*), *De divisionibus scientiarum*, simply left it untranslated as “scientia alnirangiat.” (This Arabic natural science was seized upon by the Welsh would-be imperial occult scientist John Dee (d. 1608) in particular, who glossed it simply as “[artis] magicae.”)⁴³ As for the drawing of a ritual circle on the floor—perhaps the aspect of Western magical practice that has most

Matthew Melvin-Koushki and James Pickett, “Mobilizing Magic: Occultism in Central Asia and the Continuity of High Persianate Culture under Russian Rule,” *Studia Islamica* 111, no. 2 (2016): 231–84.

42. Again, see Doostdar, *The Iranian Metaphysicals*; and Anand Vivek Taneja, *Jinnalogy: Time, Islam, and Ecological Thought in the Medieval Ruins of Delhi* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2018)—both brilliant examples of how Islamicist anthropology can and must be done going forward.

43. *Mathematicall Praeface* (London, 1570), sig. A.iiij verso; see Nicholas H. Clulee, *John Dee's Natural Philosophy: Between Science and Religion* (London: Routledge, 1988), 166–76.

endured in the popular imaginary to the present—that too seems to be an Islamicate innovation.

Most surprising, however, is the (very modest) extent to which even *lettrism* managed to penetrate Latin Christian magic: for unlike its Hebrew twin kabbalah, predicated on the Bible and hence immediately available to Christian use, the Arabic science of letters and names is irreducibly *quranic*. Nevertheless, the fact that talismanic magic became increasingly and irreversibly fused with Būnian letter magic throughout the Islamicate Mediterranean and elsewhere ensured that at least a few distinctive features of the latter would eventually trickle into western Christendom. Thus the mathematical creation of an unlimited number of new angelic names for talismanic purposes—a peculiarly lettrist technique—appears in Agrippa’s landmark *Three Books*, heavily based on the *Picatrix* as well; and thus even in eighteenth-century Germany there is evidence that the exclusively quranic form of letter magic based on the 99 Names of God was imported. This creeping awareness of Islamic lettrism among Christian kabbalists is epitomized by the Jesuit polymath-occultist Athanasius Kircher’s (d. 1680) back-to-back discussion of “Cabala Hebræorum” and “Cabala Sarcenica et Agarena,” the first such pairing.⁴⁴

But early modern Christian scholars remained largely ignorant of—and neoclassicizing humanists actively disdained—contemporary Islamicate developments in the occult sciences; modern historians and anthropologists have inherited and reproduced their ignorance and disdain.⁴⁵ Otto’s clarion call to finally study the Islamicate and Christianate halves of Western learned magic as a contiguous whole is therefore timely and encouraging, as it will help to rouse Europeanists and Islamicists alike from their complacency on this heavily embattled front. For Islamic Magic, as Otto rightly concludes, remains one of the largest black boxes in Western intellectual and cultural history. Even its so-called classical period (eighth to twelfth centuries) remains sorely understudied, despite the relative paucity and hence manageability of sources; I would add that its “postclassical”—which is to say *early modern*—era of imperial flourishing, during which the vast majority of surviving texts and artifacts were produced, remains far more so. (To be sure, many

44. *Oedipus Aegypticus*, 3 vols. (Rome, 1652–54), 2:209–400. The latter section, however, is much shorter and quite rudimentary. See Liana Saif’s forthcoming study of Kircher’s “Saracenic kabbalah.”

45. On European Renaissance humanists’ hostility to Arabic science in general and Arabic astrology in particular, see Dag Nikolaus Hasse, *Success and Suppression: Arabic Sciences and Philosophy in the Renaissance* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 2016).

Islamicate disciplines likewise remain understudied by historians to a great degree, from philosophy and poetry to astronomy and law; but few things make the modern humanist researcher more viscerally uncomfortable than Islamic Magic.) Let us therefore cease favoring unhappy magical families over happy, antagonists over protagonists, and investigate the galaxy of ways in which the Islamicate occult sciences became inextricable from elite scientific and imperial discourse and popular practice over the last millennium.



Thus concludes my summary of *Secrets*. It remains only to bring into starker relief two methodological problems recurrent in the volume that, I fear, may lead the next generation of Islamicists down a garden path: 1) the metonymical use of “magic”—based exclusively on static outsider discourse—for the Islamicate occult sciences and technologies as a whole; and 2) the assignment of this essentialized Magic strictly to the history of religion, never the history of science. Happily, however, both are problems easy enough to name and banish, the mere haunting of long colonialist–orientalist habit.

As is signaled by its subtitle, based on the originary conference title, *Secrets* purports to treat of Magic in Islam. But its various chapters cover not only magic (*sihr*)—routinely classified as one among the various natural sciences by Arabic and Persian encyclopedists—but also a wide selection of the other magical and divinatory sciences, from astrology and geomancy to lettrism and amuletry, in more than equal measure. (Alchemy is notably absent.) Divination, it bears emphasizing, must always be distinguished from magic, as even Ibn Khaldūn was aware: the first tells you the past, present, or future; the second allows you to change it.

If we are to take a discourse–historical approach, then, if we are to preferentially hew to first–order categories, as Otto advises, rather than second– or third–, then *sihr* becomes useless as an umbrella term, whether emic or etic. For while many Muslim protagonists strove to rehabilitate this loaded Arabic term, and often succeeded, none, to my knowledge, styled themselves *sāḥirs* or mages; they rather self–identified, and were identified by their biographers, as mathematical–natural scientists or philosophers generally, and masters of individual occult sciences specifically.⁴⁶ Proud lettrists (*ḥarfīs*), astrologers (*munajjims*), and geomancers (*rammāls*) abound. That is, such specialists explicitly presented the occult sciences as the chiefest modes of applied

46. The same principle applies to their Byzantine peers, who identified not as *magoi* but as *philosophoi* (“Introduction,” in *The Occult Sciences*, ed. Magdalino and Mavroudi, 13).

Neoplatonic-Neopythagorean philosophy (*ḥikma*, lit. “wisdom,” to be distinguished from mere peripatetic *falsafā*). By the early modern period, philosophers famed as both jurists and occult scientists, like the Safavid sage-mage Shaykh Bahāʾī (d. 1621), could thus be officially eulogized in Persian as being “possessed of eternal forms of knowledge (‘*ārīf-i ma‘ārīf-i azālī*), a master of sciences occult and manifest (*vāqīf-i ‘ulūm-i khafī u jalī*).”⁴⁷ Likewise Mīr Fath Allāh Shīrāzī (d. 1589), the celebrated Safavid polymath and inventor credited with bringing Islamic philosophy to Mughal India, who earned this biographical encomium:

He was a very learned scholar and superior to all the scholars of Khurasan, Iraq and India in his mastery of all types of rational (‘*aqlī*) and traditional (*naqlī*) sciences; during his lifetime he had no peer in all the world. He was also skilled in the occult sciences (‘*ulūm-i gharība*), particularly various types of talismans and spellcasting (*tilismāt, nīranjāt*).⁴⁸

Surely we must allow such careful insider distinctions, whereby the occult sciences came to be seen as an especially distinctive and coherent subset of the rational and traditional sciences, to guide our emic and etic terminology alike—rather than the facile outsider insistence on lumping them all into *siḥr*, the better to declare them illegal and their practice punishable by death.

As things stand in the literature, however, including the volume under review, adjectives like “occult,” “esoteric,” “magical,” and “mystical” are thrown around with wild abandon as essential synonyms—all meaning “things we don’t, can’t, or won’t understand as Enlightened moderns.” Needless to say, we must be far more precise in our terminology if we hope to empirically capture the nuances of constantly evolving insider discourse over space and time, lest we too condemn that discourse to historiographical death.

So we must no longer speak blithely of “Magic in Islam,” an etic umbrella category that favors outsider over insider discourse by default. (It likewise favors the popular, the marginal, and the religious over the scholarly, the mainstream, and the scientific.⁴⁹) But what should we as Islamicists call that

47. Iskandar Beg Munshī (d. 1633), *Tārīkh-i ‘Ālam-ārā-yi ‘Abbāsī*, ed. Īraj Afshār, 2 vols. (Tehran: Amīr Kabīr, 1382 Sh./2003), 2:967.

48. Nizām al-Dīn Aḥmad (d. 1594), *Ṭabaqāt-i Akbarī*, ed. Brajendranath De, 3 vols. (Calcutta: Asiatic Society, 1931–35), 2:457.

49. This trenchant point is made by Magdalino and Mavroudi in their introduction to *The Occult Sciences in Byzantium* (12–13): “[T]he concept of magic does not do justice to the learned, literate end of the spectrum. It puts the educated, sophisticated masters of occult knowledge, some of whom, in Byzantium, were leading social

vast, often ambiguous but equally often coherent object of our historical and anthropological study? Must we sacrifice catchy branding—imperative for job, funding, organizational, and publishing purposes—on the altar of emic accuracy?

Not necessarily; two viable if problematic candidates are currently being debated by specialists: *esotericism* and *occultism*. The first catchall term has the great strategic advantage of successful branding behind it. Western Esotericism (or Esoteric) Studies, as noted, is a now vibrant and burgeoning field, featuring academic units in Europe and journals and scholarly associations on both sides of the Atlantic. The only question is as to whether this designation can be made to fit the Islamicate context too, equally Western: for the field was structured at its inception exclusively on the basis of western European and primarily Christianate data, which as we have seen often tracks with contemporary Islamicate developments quite poorly indeed. (If anything, the latter should be used as scientific control for the study of the former, not vice versa, for the reasons outlined above.) But the category “Western” is here a deadfall: Henry Corbin (d. 1978), a founding father of religionism, explicitly advanced his phenomenological category of “Islamic esotericism” (or rather “Shi‘i esotericism”) as *antithesis* and *antidote* to Western modernity. Most problematically, the same Corbinian concept would seem to be inextricable from modern Traditionalist fantasies—wildly antihistorical and often racist—as to sufism or Iranian Shi‘ism being the true, perennial, spiritual essence of an otherwise Semitic and hence legalistic Islam.⁵⁰

As an Islamicist and an early modernist, I am accordingly wary of the tainted and blurry term “esotericism,” or rather find it to be more useful as a *sociological* descriptor than an *epistemological*, pursuant to common usage;⁵¹ this

figures, in the same category as the drunken old women who were caricatured, not inaccurately according to a recent authority, as the leading practitioners of magic in Late Antiquity. It also implies that they offered an alternative religion, or a superstitious substitute for orthodox cult, which was demonstrably not the case . . . [O]ccult science cannot be regarded simply as the learned and non-superstitious side of magic.”

50. Cf. Liana Saif’s preliminary redefinition of “Islamic esotericism” as a basis for its study as a separate but parallel phenomenon to Western esotericism in “What Is Islamic Esotericism? Contouring a New Field,” forthcoming as part of her special issue of *Correspondences*. In particular, she argues that the term *bāṭiniyya*, despite its polemical connotations, can nevertheless be rehabilitated for etic use.

51. As Asprem notes (“Beyond the West,” 10–11): “[T]ypologists operationalising ‘esotericism’ along the lines of ‘religious secrecy’ have a stronger historical precedence for their choice: they can amass etymological arguments, refer to common understandings as fortified in lexical definitions, and even point to a history of use that massively predates the contemporary historicist understanding.”

has the great advantage of dissociating the term from its origins in medieval Islamic and modern religionist polemic alike.⁵² For Arabic cognates (based on the adjective *bāṭin*, meaning “inner” or “hidden,” a quranic divine name, whence *bāṭinī*, “esotericist”) were historically constantly used in the first place as outsider slurs—thus the stock execration by Ghazālī specifically and Sunni scholars generally of Isma‘īlī Shi‘is as the prototypical *bāṭiniyya*. Rising to or simply ignoring such polemic, various insider groups, including Shi‘is, sufis, and philosophers concerned to protect their knowledge from uninitiated or inquisitorial eyes, nevertheless valorized ‘ilm al-*bāṭin*, or initiatic knowledge of matters spiritual or occult.⁵³ This latter emic usage is especially widespread in the early modern Persianate context with which I am most familiar, where concerns about occult-scientific secrecy—i.e., esotericism—became largely irrelevant, and the medieval esotericist ethos a mere *topos*: hence the preferred descriptor in Persian, and increasingly in Arabic too, for the occult sciences as *gharīb*—now meaning not “strange,” but fundamentally *elite*.⁵⁴

Equally importantly, it must be stressed that even non-perennialist Islamicists have long habitually conflated “esotericism” and “mysticism,” with the pernicious effect of historiographically rendering sufism (*taṣawwuf*) the

52. To be clear: the problem is not the “medievalness” of a given polemic, but simply that Islamicists to date have too often relied on such medieval polemic, to the exclusion of insider discourses, to construct their own, equally polemical definitions of medieval, early modern, and modern Islamicate occultism as an undifferentiated and timeless unit.

53. For a brief discussion and references see Michael Ebstein, *Mysticism and Philosophy in al-Andalus: Ibn Masarra, Ibn al-‘Arabī and the Ismā‘īlī Tradition* (Leiden: Brill, 2014), 26 n. 79.

54. Melvin-Koushki, “Powers of One,” 137. This point is confirmed already in the twelfth century by no less a luminary than the philosopher-theologian Fakhr al-Dīn Rāzī (d. 1210), who in his *Compendium of the Sciences* (*Jāmi‘ al-‘ulūm*), the first comprehensive Persian encyclopedia of the rational and religious sciences, introduces his eastern scholarly readership to the new occult science of geomancy (‘ilm al-*raml*) by specifically styling it *gharīb*. In his entry on physiognomy (‘ilm al-*firāsa*), an occult science well known from Hellenic antiquity, he further glosses *gharīb* as *sharīf*—precisely meaning “elite” (ed. Sayyid ‘Alī Āl-i Dāwūd [Tehran: Surayyā, 2003], 268, 432). This is not to say, however, that Islamicate occultist and esotericist discourses alike are not epistemologically predicated on a *ẓāhir/bāṭin*, or manifest/occult, binary, derived from the same quranic divine names. Early modern lettrists in particular took as their motto and rallying call the verse *He is the First and the Last, the Manifest and the Occult* (Q 57:3), epitomizing their master principle of the *coincidentia oppositorum* (*majma‘ al-aḍḍād*); see Matthew Melvin-Koushki, “Imperial Talismanic Love: Ibn Turka’s *Debate of Feast and Fight* (1426) as Philosophical Romance and Lettrist Mirror for Timurid Princes,” *Der Islam* 96, no. 1 (2019): 42–86.

default form of “Islamic esotericism,” into which category the various occult sciences may be safely disappeared, or from which neatly cleaved. And so they have almost entirely been to date: historians of sufism greatly outnumber Islamicist historians of science, and never the twain shall meet.⁵⁵ To be sure, many sufis were also occult scientists (as well as many other things besides), and some of them certainly were secretive as to their religious and scientific practices, or otherwise on the margins of society. (Alchemy is here an esotericist case in point.⁵⁶) But far more sufis were not occult scientists, nor secretive or socially marginal in the slightest. To the contrary: historically and to the present, sufism was and is a highly institutionally visible and socially, economically, and sometimes even militarily and politically hegemonic force. Indeed, the early modern Persianate world was defined by the contest between sultans and saints for political control of Islamdom; the messianic *sufi saint-kings* who became the Safavids won that contest in Iran—wielding not a little *war magic*. As a historian of precisely this *imperialization* of occult science and sainthood in tandem, I simply can’t see such scientific-religious Sturm und Drang, which by the sixteenth century swept up a full third of the Afro-Eurasian ecumene in its culturally transformative trammels, as being *esoteric* in any meaningful way. Science, Religion, and Empire were, and are, inextricable.

I therefore prefer “occultism” (or “occult science”) as the best of a bad etic lot. The admittedly distracting resemblance to the “occultisme” of nineteenth-century French vintage notwithstanding—a cultural phenomenon of less Western and global historical significance by several orders of magnitude—the English term tracks to the consistent identification in Arabic and Persian insider sources of the occult sciences as precisely *occult* (*khafī*) in order to designate these natural, mathematical, and/or religious sciences as epistemologically *and* sociologically valid. And beyond its semantic precision, this descriptor has the added virtue, emic and etic, of never having been used by Muslim polemicists to damn heretics, in extreme contrast to *bāṭinī*. Indeed, an Arabic substantive to render “occultism” is grammatically unfeasible in this case: *khafiyya* variously denotes a well, a covert, a secret, or a slight

55. An exception is Robert G. Morrison, *Islam and Science: The Intellectual Career of Nizām al-Dīn al-Nīsābūrī* (London: Routledge, 2007).

56. On the persistence of an esotericist ethos among Arabic alchemists in the early modern era, see Nicholas Harris, “Better Religion through Chemistry: Aydemir al-Jildakī and Alchemy under the Mamluks” (Ph.D. diss., University of Pennsylvania, forthcoming 2020); Tuna Artun, “Hearts of Gold and Silver: Production of Alchemical Knowledge in the Early Modern Ottoman World” (Ph.D. diss., Princeton University, 2013).

touch of insanity.⁵⁷ (Similarly, “lettrism” tracks to the Arabo-Persian self-designations *ahl al-ḥarf*, *ḥarfī*, and *ḥurūfī*, all translatable only as “lettrist”; that a minor French Dadaist movement of the mid-twentieth century playfully dubbed itself the Lettrist International hardly invalidates the term for emic or etic use.) For an occult science, pursued esoterically or not, is simply *a discipline in which one extrapolates from visible to invisible data*: thus the frequent classification of medicine (*‘ilm al-ṭibb*) as an occult science, in contradistinction to surgery (*‘ilm al-tashrīḥ*). It must be emphasized, moreover, that by the early modern period roughly *half* of the Arabo-Persian natural and mathematical sciences explicitly fit this description, and were clearly widely and publicly practiced, so can hardly be described as “esoteric,” or disappeared into “magic” or “mysticism” or both.⁵⁸ As for branding: In my experience, *occultism*, unlike *esotericism*, has the added advantage of being somewhat catchier, if equally misleading, to a nonspecialist anglophone audience; my students (I teach at a big state research university in the American South) tell me “it just sounds cooler.”

As distinct but highly contested etic categories, in sum, occultism and mysticism certainly overlap with one another, and both with esotericism; to what degree depends on time and place, as well as individual proclivity. Different historians, naturally, will need to cut these etic pies in different ways depending on their focus and theoretical commitments. My own project is the empirical, philological reconstruction of the intellectual and sociopolitical history of the various Islamicate occult sciences, classified as such, in the early modern Persianate world—for that history remains almost wholly unwritten; to indulge in theory at this very early historiographical stage seems premature. And yet the astonishing richness of my archive cries out for broad intra-Western comparison, however preliminary and impressionistic. To do justice to my early modern Islamicate material, therefore, to open it to comparativist study, I must be able to efficiently analytically capture such epochal cultural processes as the *sanctification*, *de-esotericization*, and *imperialization of occultism*, which proceeded in distinct regional and temporal stages, from Iberia to India, and from the twelfth century to the seventeenth, rendering Islamicate early modernity rather dramatically divergent from Christianate. Put simply:

57. The related adjective *khāfi*—associated in the first place rather with jinn—would produce the very awkward *khāfiyya*: a gang of occultist genies?

58. Melvin-Koushki, “Powers of One.” Emically, both *siḥr* and *taṣawwuf* always appear as discrete sciences in the Arabo-Persian encyclopedic tradition, the first natural and the second religious, and are never used as umbrella terms for the occult sciences (including magic) as an epistemologically distinct group.

Muslim occultists had (and have) even less need to be esoteric—by which I mean secretive—than their Christian peers.

Secrets too documents all three processes, as I have noted; this is its most vital intervention in and contribution to the nascent field of Islamicate Occultism-and-Esotericism Studies. But does it otherwise deliver on the promise of its subtitle, *Magic in Islam between Religion and Science*?

Unfortunately not: the volume's overreliance on antagonist discourse, on the one hand, and its conflation of *occult-esoteric-magical-mystical*, on the other, commits it to an exclusively *religionist* approach. This is a perfectly valid one, needless to say; but apart from a few passing acknowledgements as to the historical status of certain occult sciences as applied natural sciences, a parallel history of science approach is utterly absent, to say nothing of science and empire studies. Those few chapters that do make explicit their analytical framing insist univocally, as we have seen, on the identity of “magic” and “religion”; several others seem to assume the same. The third element of the deeply colonialist Science-Religion-Magic anthropological triad has magically vanished.

The editors' introduction attempts to ameliorate this yawning lacuna by briefly surveying three important classifications of the sciences (sg. *taṣnīf al-ʿulūm*), one Persian and two Arabic, and Ilkhanid, Mamluk, and Ottoman respectively. The Iranian philosopher-astronomer Qutb al-Dīn Shīrāzī's (d. 1311) *Pearl in the Crown* (*Durrat al-tāf*), counteracting Ibn Sīnā's (d. 1037) critique of astrology and alchemy, robustly reasserts the status of various occult sciences as the backbone of natural philosophy: *for they are the disciplines that study and seek to technologically harness mind-matter, matter-matter and mind-mind interactions*. So too does the Cairene physician-chemist Ibn al-Akfānī's (d. 1348) *Guidance for Seekers of the Sublimest of Goals* (*Irshād al-qāṣid ilā asnā l-maqāṣid*), which became the model for all subsequent Arabic encyclopedias, including in the first place the *Key to Felicity and Lamp to Mastery* (*Miftāḥ al-saʿāda wa-miṣbāḥ al-siyāda*) of the Ottoman polymath Taṣköprüzāde Aḥmed (d. 1561), which expands on it significantly, adding many more occult-scientific disciplines and subdisciplines. This last is held up as epitomizing the sophistication, complexity, and mainstream status of Islamicate occult-scientific theory and practice by the sixteenth century—as indeed it does.

Nevertheless, this choice of encyclopedias, together with their very truncated and decontextualized presentation, renders invisible precisely those two processes that ensured the centrality of occult science to early modern Islamicate scientific, religious, and imperial cultures: their *mathematization* on the one hand, and their *sanctification* on the other. On the latter front, Taṣköprüzāde is most instructive: for he reclassifies a number of occult

sciences—most notably including lettrism—from the natural and mathematical sciences to the religious sciences. (Such a move accords with the tendency of *Secrets* too.) But he makes this distinctly conservative move only in response to the *Persian* encyclopedic tradition, where the occult sciences were increasingly reclassified from the natural to the mathematical sciences from the twelfth century onward, this in order to assert their empirical virtue in the face of four centuries of polemic. By the fifteenth century, moreover, certain occult sciences, especially lettrism and alchemy, were conceived of as simultaneously mathematical, natural, *and* religious sciences—an epistemological and sociological both-andness that makes a mockery of our neat history of religion and history of science disciplinary camps.

Within the broader Western intellectual-historical context, the distinctiveness of the Islamicate occult sciences as a unit lies in the fact that they were the only sciences to successfully formally synthesize and transcend the otherwise strict epistemic and generic boundaries between the *rational* and the *religious*—i.e., the Hellenic and the Islamic—sciences. This distinctiveness is lost in *Secrets*, which is theoretically fixated almost exclusively on Religion. At the risk of seeming presumptuous, then, I propose the following subtitle as more apt: *Islamicate Occultism in the History and Anthropology of Religion*.

I do not mean to suggest, however, that there are not serious obstacles to such a simultaneous, two-eyed, science-and-religion approach. Indeed, the persistent hostility of Islamicist historians of science to occult science even now—recent summae dismiss astrology and lettrism as “pseudoscience” and “cultic” respectively!—must discourage all but the most dogged from this feat.⁵⁹ But we must attempt it nonetheless, lest the irreducibly and transgressively hybrid nature of Occult Science be occulted from our historiographical and anthropological purview.

Speaking of *occultation*: Given the jarringly Ibn Khaldūnian tenor of a not inconsiderable fraction of *Secrets*, I must reiterate in closing that we Islamicists must be more wary of inadvertently validating that historian’s antihistorical project to conflate and demonize the occult and the esoteric, the magical and the mystical, in equal measure. Great indeed are the perils of relying on outsider discourses over insider for reconstructing the intellectual and sociopolitical histories of Islam, whether in the precolonial fourteenth century or the postcolonial present. But modern historians and anthropologists, like medieval theologians, have too often stooped to the same old polemic.

59. On such historiographical hostility see Melvin-Koushki, “Powers of One,” 179–84.

I therefore end with the eloquent testimony of none other than the Egyptian ultramodernist and secularist Ṭāhā Ḥusayn, who in his famed autobiography (discussed by Enderwitz in her chapter) holds up Ibn Khaldūnism as *sociological nonsense*—yet also poignantly prognosticates the Protestantization of Islam, and the attendant reduction of high occult science to popular, illegitimate religion, by colonialists, orientalist, and reformists—including Ḥusayn himself—all striving to that end. Here he describes his childhood curriculum, at the turn of the twentieth century, as emblematic of an Egypt only recently vanished, wherein a sanctified, Būnian magic had enjoyed cultural hegemony for over half a millennium:

Our little boy [i.e., the author himself] lost no time in adding to these stripes of learning a further one: the science of magic and talismans (*‘ilm al-siḥr wa-l-ṭalāsim*). For booksellers would cart about the villages and cities a motley mix of books (which together constituted perhaps the truest epitome of the beliefs of the populace at large in those days), [among them] hagiographies . . . and the *Great Sun of Knowledge* on magic . . . Our little friend was read to from all this mix, and he retained much of it; but he was interested in two things above all: magic and mysticism (*taṣawwuf*). He thought it neither strange nor difficult to combine these two disciplines—for any contradiction they seem to have is in fact merely superficial.

Does not the sufi claim to himself and to others that he can tear away the veils of the unseen, prognosticate past and future, transcend the laws of nature and perform all manner of miracles? And what does the mage do? Does he too not assert for himself the ability to speak of the unseen, to transcend the laws of nature and penetrate to the realm of the spirits? Of course. The only difference between the mage and the sufi is that one attains thereto by means of angels and the other by means of demons. But here we must read the likes of Ibn Khaldūn to understand such a distinction, and so derive the natural consequence that magic is to be forbidden and avoided, while mysticism is to be encouraged and embraced.

Nothing could be farther from our little boy and his friends than Ibn Khaldūn and the likes of Ibn Khaldūn! There fell into their eager hands books on magic and hagiographies and tales of the miracles of the saints, and they read and were much taken with them all; indeed, they soon moved from reading and mere admiration to emulation and practice. They performed the exercises of the sufis, and like mages attained competence in various branches of that art, till magic and mysticism become inextricable in their minds, or rather a single thing. Its goal: to ease life and ensure closeness with God.⁶⁰

60. *Al-Ayyām* (Cairo: Markaz al-Ahrām, 1412/1992), 82–83.

This volume's theoretical and thematic shortcomings and strengths are, in sum, simply those of the still-young field of Islamic Studies itself; it will nevertheless ease the life of the Islamicist seeking closeness with Magic. Read in tandem with its sister volumes, *Die Geheimnisse der oberen und der unteren Welt* constitutes a solid philological-bibliographical foundation and bold advertisement for the long-overdue turn to Occult Science among Islamicists, who have tarried far behind their Europeanist, Judaicist, Classicist, and anthropologist counterparts in this crucial regard—and still frequently and antihistorically insist on their subject as Religion, not Science, much less Empire.